



French Revolution

Revolution broke out in 1789, sweeping away the king and nobility. A new National Assembly was set up, and swore the famous tennis court oath, that they would not disband until France had a proper constitution. Napoleon Bonaparte became Emperor in 1804, marking the end of the revolutionary period.

Monarchy and empire

After the defeat of Napoleon in 1815, France had a series of short-lived, weak governments. The restored Bourbon monarchy was overthrown in 1830 and King Louis Philippe lost his throne in 1848. The resulting Second Republic collapsed when its president, Louis-Napoleon (r.1852–70), became emperor. In spite of these problems, France grew prosperous.

Revolution of 1848

In February 1848, Parisians rose up against their ineffectual king, Louis Philippe. A republic was set up, with Louis-Napoleon, a nephew of Bonaparte, as president. Radical reforms were promised, but in 1852 Napoleon became emperor.

Revolutionaries in Paris, 1848



Infantryman's pack, Franco-Prussian War



Franco-Prussian War

Although successful at home, Napoleon III was no match for Bismarck, chancellor of Prussia. In 1870, rivalry between France and Prussia led to war, but the French armies were unprepared and were soon defeated. France lost the provinces of Alsace and Lorraine to Germany.

J'Accuse...!

LITTÉRAIRE, ARTISTIQUE, SOCIALE

LETTRE AU PRÉSIDENT DE LA RÉPUBLIQUE

Par ÉMILE ZOLA

Third Republic

The Third Republic (1870–1940) was riven with internal disputes and conflicts between moderates, radicals, socialists, and royalists. Between 1918 and its collapse in 1940, there were 44 governments and 20 different prime ministers. Yet France stayed one of the leading states in Europe, with a worldwide empire and a strong economy.

J'Accuse, writer Emile Zola's pamphlet supporting Dreyfus

Dreyfus case

In October 1894, French army captain Alfred Dreyfus was court-martialled for treason, for passing military secrets to Germany. But a mistake had been made, and a campaign to free Dreyfus began. He was cleared in 1906, but the case split the nation between his supporters and those who refused to change the verdict.

Vichy France

In 1940, German forces invaded France. French general and right-wing politician Marshal Pétain set up a government in Vichy, central France. This government collaborated with the occupying forces; opposition was led from London by Charles de Gaulle, leader of the Free French. Vichy France was occupied by the Germans in 1942.



Cross of Lorraine

Flag of the Free French

Modern France

After the liberation of France from German occupation in 1944, a Fourth Republic was set up to govern the country. Like its predecessor, it was weak and was brought down by the unrest caused by the Algerian war in 1958. Charles de Gaulle then set up the Fifth Republic, aiming to restore French prestige and prosperity.

Charles de Gaulle

Charles de Gaulle (1890–1970) trained as a soldier, rising to command an armoured division. On the fall of France in 1940, he fled to Britain and called on French people to resist German occupation. As leader of the Free French, he did much to boost French morale during the war. In 1958 he became president, leading his country until he resigned in 1969.



May 1968

In May 1968, students demanding more money for education demonstrated against high defence spending. Riots broke out in Paris and elsewhere, with fighting between police and students. A general strike ensued, and de Gaulle's government was weakened.

After the riots, Paris, May 1968

Algerian war

In 1954, Algeria, one of several African countries colonized by France, demanded that it be granted its independence. This led to conflict with the many European settlers in the country. The French army supported the settlers in their wish to remain French and waged a vicious war against the Algerian rebels. Algeria finally won its independence in 1962.



Timeline

58–51 BC Gaul (present-day France) becomes part of the Roman Empire.

AD 486 The Franks take control of the country.

1337–1453 France and Britain fight the Hundred Years' War.



1589 Henry IV becomes first Bourbon king.

1643–1715 France reaches height of its power under Louis XIV.

1789 Revolution breaks out in Paris.

Encyclopédie, 1751

1848 After a revolution, the short-lived Second Republic is established.

1870–71 Third Republic set up.

1870s Impressionist movement founded by Claude Monet and other French painters.



Claude Monet, *Waterlilies*

1914–18 France fights Germany in World War I.

1946 Fourth Republic established after World War II.

1958 De Gaulle takes power and introduces Fifth Republic.

1950s–90s France is a leading member of European Union.

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